S5 Table.

Prior work and how this study relates to it

Supporting information for "Environmental fluctuation limits gene regulation unless it can be tracked"

The table sets out which parts of the argument are established in the literature, which conflict with our results, and which we did not find precedent for. Literature searches covered theory of plasticity and cue reliability, gene-regulatory-network evolution under fluctuating selection, digital evolution (Avida, Aevol), network sparseness and modularity, and weighted network measures.

Claim	Status	Sources and relation to this study
Reliable cues favour plastic responses; without them, fluctuation favours generalists, bet-hedging or genetic tracking	Established	Levins 1968 [1]; Moran 1992 [2]; Kussell and Leibler 2005 [3]; Botero et al. 2015 [4]; Ashander et al. 2016 [5], in which responding to a poorly predictive cue amplifies mismatch. Our results concern the corresponding effect on the regulatory network.
In slowly changing environments populations track the environment genetically instead of evolving plasticity	Established	Botero et al. 2015 [4]; Rago et al. 2019 [6]. Consistent with the better match to the target, without a change in regulation, at coarse grain in R-Aevol.
In a gene regulatory network model, plasticity evolves mainly under fast, erratic change with reliable cues	Established	Jorritsma and van den Berg 2026 [7] (read in the authors' manuscript): a fixed four-node network, change between generations only, 1,000 replicates. They show link strengths schematically by cue reliability. Reliable cues give strong links from the regulatory genes to the output; uninformative cues (reliability 0, drawn uniformly) give networks that ignore the cue and have strong links within the regulatory layer. They do not compare with a constant environment, separate the cue's own links from the network, or let genome size evolve.
In a network with a dedicated sensor gene, discrete plasticity evolves as the sensor comes to activate some genes and repress others	Published	Sakamoto and Innan 2024 [8]. The sensor is always informative and gene number does not evolve, so neither an uninformative-cue control nor genome size is examined. EvoSim's sensor node follows the same design.
Fluctuating environments can select for or against gene regulation	Established experimentally	Pollack, Nozoe and Kussell 2025 [9], who report that catabolite symport flux strongly affects selection for regulation and note that laboratory evolution under metabolic fluctuation often loses the regulation of metabolic genes.

Claim	Status	Sources and relation to this study
Fluctuation without information about the optimum promotes complex regulatory networks	Published for a random-walk optimum; conflicts with our R-Aevol results	Tsuda and Kawata 2010 [10]. Their optimum moved across generations, and the networks received an on/off signal that carried no information about its position. The effect was strong for a random walk and slight, limited to large and infrequent shifts, for an optimum alternating between two positions, which is the pattern of our design. Our grain experiment found that grain does not reconcile the two results. The remaining candidate explanations are the novel optima of the random walk and differences in the genotype–phenotype map.
Fluctuating environments favour larger genomes	Published; matches earlier EvoSim results	Bentkowski et al. 2015 [11]. R-Aevol shows the opposite.
Environmental change speeds up the evolution of regulatory complexity without raising its final level	Published, different measure	Chapel and de Boer 2026 [12]: fixed numbers of genes and regulators and no cue; complexity is how evenly the regulators share control of each gene, and populations evolving without selection reach the same level. Regulatory strength and network size, which our results concern, are not measured.
Genome size is limited by selection for mutational robustness and falls with population size and mutation rate	Established in Aevol	Knibbe et al. 2007 [13]; Luiselli et al. 2024 [14]. Consistent with the small genomes in large EvoSim populations.
Sensing and non-sensing populations evolve differently in fluctuating environments	Published, different measures	Lalejini et al. 2021 [15] (Avida), measuring trait loss and the accumulation of deleterious mutations. Network architecture was not measured.
Network models with and without a cue input compared	Published	Ng and Kinjo 2023 [16] and 2024 [17]; plasticity-led evolution appears only with the cue input, and network density is fixed by the mutation operator. Removing the cue changes its presence and its information together, the confound the yoked control removes.
Regulatory complexity is measured by counting genes or edges	Common practice	Tsuda and Kawata 2010 [10] (gene numbers, degree distributions); Espinosa-Soto 2018 [18] (binary edges, weights not discussed).
Network size and connectivity can grow without selection for them	Established	Soyer and Bonhoeffer 2006 [19].
The number of transcription factors scales faster than genome size and is higher in free-living bacteria	Established; two interpretations	Comparative genomics links it to lifestyle and environmental variety (van Nimwegen 2003 [20]; Cases, de Lorenzo and Ouzounis 2003 [21]). R-Aevol simulations reproduce the scaling and attribute it to mutation and rearrangement rates instead of lifestyle (Beslon et al. 2010 [22]).
Summed edge strength as a network measure	Standard method	Iwasaki, Tsuda and Kawata 2013 [23].
The yoked control	Established in the study of learning	Church 1964 [24] describes a bias that arises when individual subjects are paired; our arms are not paired, so it does not apply.

Claim	Status	Sources and relation to this study
Not found in the literature		
Edge count does not track edge strength under fluctuation	This study	EvoSim (exploratory; more edges with the same total strength), R-Aevol informative-cue populations (pre-registered secondary analysis; no more links but stronger regulation).
A yoked control that separates a cue's information from its presence in the evolution of regulatory networks	This study	R-Aevol, with the rates of target and signal change matched between arms (S2 Text). The zero-reliability cue of [7] is present but uninformative; it is drawn uniformly, so its statistics are not matched to those of the informative cue.
Regulatory strength and genome size compared across informative, yoked and absent cues	This study	Pre-registered predictions P1–P4 and the confirmation C1–C4; [7] reports link strengths schematically across cue reliabilities under fluctuation only.

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